

No. of evaluators & problems

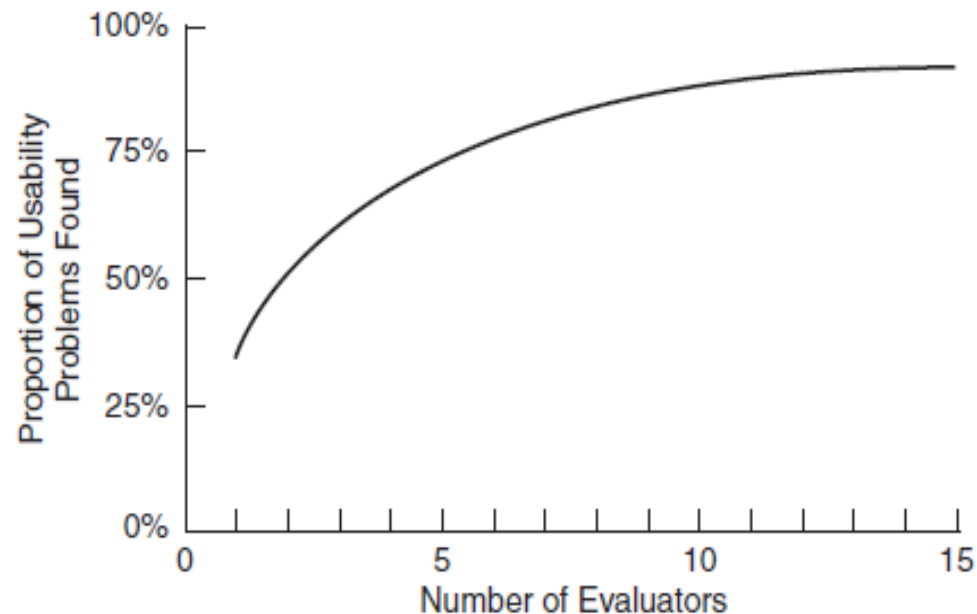


Figure 15.1 Curve showing the proportion of usability problems in an interface found by heuristic evaluation using various numbers of evaluators. The curve represents the average of six case studies of heuristic evaluation

Source: Usability Inspection Methods, J. Nielson & R.L. Mack ©1994. Reproduced with permission of John Wiley & Sons Inc.

Number of evaluators

- Nielsen suggests that on average 5 evaluators identify 75-80% of usability problems.
- Cockton and Woolrych (2001) point out that the number of users needed to find 75-80% of usability problems depends on the context and nature of the problems.

Heuristics for websites focus on key criteria (Budd, 2007)

- Clarity
 - Make system clear, concise, and meaningful as possible.
- Minimize unnecessary complexity & cognitive load
 - Make system as simple as possible to accomplish the task.
- Provide users with context
 - Interface should provide users with a sense of context in time and space.
- Promote positive & pleasurable user experience
 - Users should be treated with respect, and design should be aesthetically pleasing and promote a pleasurable and rewarding experience.

3 stages for doing heuristic evaluation

- Briefing session to tell experts what to do.
- Evaluation period of 1-2 hours in which:
 - Each expert works separately;
 - Take one pass to get a feel for the product;
 - Take a second pass to focus on specific features.
- Debriefing session in which experts work together to prioritize problems.

Advantages and problems

- Few ethical & practical issues to consider because users not involved.
- Can be difficult & expensive to find experts.
- Best experts have knowledge of application domain & users.
- Biggest problems:
 - Important problems may get missed;
 - Many trivial problems are often identified;
 - Experts have biases.